

P. A. H. Solapur University, Solapur
B.A., B.Com. B.Sc. ECS., B.C.A-II
English Part-II Reading Texts in Indian English – II [AEC] [MIL]

Semester- IV

I Poetry:

1. Hunger: Jayanta Mahapatra
2. The Right Image: Agha Shahid Ali
3. Sunrise: Padma Sachdev
4. The House of My Childhood: Dilip Chitre

II Prose:

1. The Nation: Rabindranath Tagore
2. Unity of Mind: A.P.J. Abdul Kalam
3. Sudha Murty: The Woman who Inspires Many: by Reena Shah

Question Paper Pattern

Total Marks: 30

- Q.1. Choose the correct alternatives from the following. (Unit 1 & 2) Marks: 6
- Q.2. Answer any two out of four of the following. (Unit 1 & 2) Marks: 6
- Q.3. Write short notes on any one of the two questions. (Unit 1) Marks: 6
- Q.4. A broad question with alternatives (A/B). (Unit 2) Marks: 12

1. Hunger: Jayanta Mahapatra

It was hard to believe the flesh was heavy on my back.
The fisherman said: Will you have her, carelessly,
trailing his nets and his nerves, as though his words
sanctified the purpose with which he faced himself.
I saw his white bone thrash his eyes.

I followed him across the sprawling sands,
my mind thumping in the flesh's sling.
Hope lay perhaps in burning the house I lived in.
Silence gripped my sleeves; his body clawed at the froth
his old nets had only dragged up from the seas.

In the flickering dark his lean-to opened like a wound.
The wind was I, and the days and nights before.
Palm fronds scratched my skin. Inside the shack
an oil lamp splayed the hours bunched to those walls.
Over and over the sticky soot crossed the space of my mind.

I heard him say: My daughter, she's just turned fifteen...
Feel her. I'll be back soon, your bus leaves at nine.
The sky fell on me, and a father's exhausted wile.
Long and lean, her years were cold as rubber.
She opened her wormy legs wide. I felt the hunger there,
the other one, the fish slithering, turning inside

About the Poet:

Jayanta Mahapatra was a renowned Indian poet who wrote mainly in English and Odia and is considered one of the most important figures in modern Indian English poetry. He was born on 22 October 1928 in Cuttack. Before becoming a well-known poet, he worked as a physics teacher and later taught at Ravenshaw University. Mahapatra began writing poetry in the 1960s, and his works often explored themes such as Indian culture, poverty, human suffering, spirituality, and personal identity. Some of his famous poems include Indian summer, Hunger, and Dawn at Puri. His poetry collection Relationship won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1981, making him the first Indian poet to receive this award for English poetry. For his contribution

to literature, he was also honoured with the Padma Shri in 2009. Jayanta Mahapatra passed away on 27 August 2023, but he remains an important and influential voice in Indian literature.

About the Poem:

The poem "Hunger" is one of Jayanta Mahapatra's most famous and controversial poems. Written in the 1970s, it addresses the grim realities of poverty, exploitation, and sexual violence in rural India. The poem is based on a real-life incident witnessed by the poet along the coast of Odisha. Through a shocking narrative, Mahapatra exposes the inhuman choices driven by hunger—the literal hunger for food and the metaphorical hunger for the flesh. The poem challenges the reader to confront uncomfortable truths about human suffering, the commodification of women, and the moral collapse brought about by extreme deprivation.

"Hunger" is a dramatic monologue that recounts a disturbing encounter between the speaker, a fisherman, and the fisherman's young daughter. The fisherman, desperate for survival, offers his fifteen-year-old daughter to the narrator in exchange for money—her body sold as a way to feed the family. The speaker is haunted by the experience, recognizing two types of hunger: his own sexual desire and the more pressing hunger for food that drives the fisherman and his daughter to such desperate measures. The poem ends with the speaker's profound sense of guilt, helplessness, and existential anguish.

Themes:

1. Poverty and Exploitation

The central theme is the devastating impact of poverty, which drives people to inhuman choices and the exploitation of the vulnerable.

2. Sexuality and Guilt

The poem explores the dark side of human desire, focusing on the speaker's guilt and complicity in the exploitation of a child.

3. Parent-Child Relationship

The transactional exchange between father and daughter is a brutal subversion of the parental role, revealing the dehumanizing power of hunger.

4. Social Critique

Mahapatra critiques a society in which such transactions are possible, exposing the failure of social, economic, and moral systems.

5. Hunger as Metaphor

Hunger operates on two levels: physical (hunger for food) and psychological (hunger for sex, power, or escape). Both hungers are destructive.

Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

1. What is the central theme of "Hunger"?

- a. Love and romance
- b. Social injustice and poverty
- c. The beauty of nature
- d. Religious devotion

Answer: b) Social injustice and poverty

2. What does the fisherman in the poem offer the speaker?

- a) A meal
- b) His fishing net
- c) His daughter
- d) Shelter for the night

Answer: c) His daughter

3. What literary device is used when the poem contrasts physical hunger with sexual hunger?

- a) Hyperbole
- b) Juxtaposition

- c) Alliteration
- d) Personification

Answer:

- b) Juxtaposition

4. How does Mahapatra create a sense of unease in the poem?

- a) Through the use of humor
- b) Through vivid and unsettling imagery
- c) Through a romanticized description of the sea
- d) By focusing on an uplifting ending

Answer: b) Through vivid and unsettling imagery

5. What does the sea symbolize in the poem?

- a) Hope and renewal
- b) Freedom and adventure
- c) The indifferent, endless cycle of suffering
- d) A boundary between life and death

Answer: c) The indifferent, endless cycle of suffering

6. What is the significance of the fisherman's daughter in the poem?

- a) She represents innocence and the tragedy of survival
- b) She symbolizes rebellion against patriarchy
- c) She is a metaphor for wealth and prosperity
- d) She represents divine intervention

Answer: a) She represents innocence and the tragedy of survival

7. What emotion does the narrator experience at the end of the poem?

- a) Joy
- b) Satisfaction

- c) Guilt and discomfort
- d) Anger

Answer: c) Guilt and discomfort

8. What does the poem critique about society?

- a) The importance of tradition
- b) The inequalities and moral compromises caused by poverty
- c) The power of religious faith
- d) The beauty of rural life

Answer: b) The inequalities and moral compromises caused by poverty

9. Who is Jayanta Mahapatra?

- A) A famous Indian actor
- B) A renowned Indian poet who wrote in English and Odia
- C) A physicist
- D) A politician

Answer: B) A renowned Indian poet who wrote in English and Odia

10. In which year did Jayanta Mahapatra win the Sahitya Akademi Award for English poetry?

- A) 1978
- B) 1981
- C) 1995
- D) 2001

Answer: B) 1981

11. Which of the following poems is written by Jayanta Mahapatra?

- A) Gitanjali
- B) Hunger

- C) The Raven
- D) The Waste Land

Answer: B) Hunger

12. What is the central theme of the poem “Hunger”?

- A) Nature's beauty
- B) Spirituality
- C) Poverty and Exploitation
- D) Childhood innocence

Answer: C) Poverty and Exploitation

13. What does the fisherman offer his daughter for in the poem “Hunger”?

- A) Money
- B) Water
- C) Shelter
- D) Education

Answer: A) Money

14. The "Hunger" poem explores two types of hunger. Which of the following is one of them?

- A) Hunger for knowledge
- B) Hunger for food and hunger for sex
- C) Hunger for power
- D) Hunger for love

Answer: B) Hunger for food and hunger for sex

15. What is the fisherman's main motivation for selling his daughter in the poem "Hunger"?

- A) Desire for a better life
- B) To feed his family
- C) To gain respect
- D) To escape poverty

Answer: B) To feed his family

16. What is the speaker's reaction at the end of the poem "Hunger"?

- A) Joy and satisfaction
- B) Hope for change
- C) Guilt, helplessness, and existential anguish
- D) Indifference

Answer: C) Guilt, helplessness, and existential anguish

17. In the poem "Hunger," which relationship is explored in a transactional manner?

- A) Teacher-Student
- B) Parent-Child
- C) Friends
- D) Husband-Wife

Answer: B) Parent-Child

18. What does the poem "Hunger" critique in terms of society?

- A) The political system
- B) The failure of social, economic, and moral systems
- C) The education system
- D) The healthcare system

Answer: B) The failure of social, economic, and moral systems

19. What does hunger symbolize in the poem "Hunger"?

- A) Only the physical need for food
- B) Only sexual desire
- C) Both physical hunger for food and psychological hunger for sex, power, or escape
- D) Only a metaphor for spiritual longing

Answer: C) Both physical hunger for food and psychological hunger for sex, power, or escape

20. How does the poem "Hunger" challenge the reader?

- A) By showing the beauty of nature
- B) By confronting uncomfortable truths about human suffering and exploitation
- C) By focusing on the power of love
- D) By discussing the importance of education

Answer: B) By confronting uncomfortable truths about human suffering and exploitation

Q.2 Answer the following questions:

1. How does the poet describe the physical effects of hunger in the poem "*Hunger*"?
2. What does hunger symbolize in Jayanta Mahapatra's "*Hunger*"?
3. How does the poet convey the emotional and psychological impact of hunger?
4. Explain the significance of the imagery of hunger in the poem "*Hunger*".
5. How does the poet portray the social aspect of hunger in the poem?
6. Why does the poet refer to hunger as a force that "invades" the body? What does this reveal about its impact?
7. How does the poet describe the feeling of hunger in the poem?
8. What does hunger represent in the poem?
9. How does the poet show that hunger affects both the body and the mind?

10. What is the main idea or message of the poem "*Hunger*"?
11. How does hunger make the people in the poem feel?

Q.3 Write short notes:

1. Discuss how Jayanta Mahapatra uses hunger as a symbol of poverty and social inequality in the poem "*Hunger*".
2. Explain the contrast between physical hunger and existential longing in "*Hunger*." How does this contribute to the meaning of the poem?
3. Analyze the tone of the poem "*Hunger*" and explain how it helps to convey the suffering of the hungry.
4. In "*Hunger*," the poet focuses on both personal and societal suffering. Discuss the dual representation of hunger in the poem.
5. Explain the role of imagery and symbolism in conveying the poet's message in "*Hunger*."
6. What are the effects of hunger on the body and mind as described in the poem?
7. How does Jayanta Mahapatra show the pain of hunger in the poem?
8. What does the poem say about the connection between hunger and social problems?

2. The Right Image: Agha Shahid Ali

The right image is a lake
Under my heart.
Not one swan but a flock,
all black, is cutting
the reflection
of a moon that is not there.

About the Poet:

Agha Shahid Ali (1949–2001) was a renowned Kashmiri-American poet who is widely celebrated for his emotional and deeply reflective poetry. Born in Kashmir, a region ravaged by conflict and political turmoil, Shahid Ali spent much of his life in exile, particularly in the United States. Despite living away from his homeland, his heart remained rooted in Kashmir, and many of his poems reflect his profound love for the region, as well as the pain of being separated from it. His poetry explores themes of loss, longing, and the struggles of living in exile.

Shahid Ali's work is known for its lyrical beauty and vivid imagery. He often used traditional forms of poetry, particularly the ghazal, which is a Persian style, but infused it with his personal experiences and feelings. His poems frequently evoke symbols such as the moon, lakes, and swans to express deep emotional states, including sorrow, yearning, and a sense of absence.

One of the key themes in Shahid Ali's poetry is loss, whether it's the loss of a loved one, the loss of home, or the loss of peace in his war-torn homeland. His poetry does not just reflect his own grief but speaks to universal experiences of separation and desire. His exploration of spiritual and philosophical themes, influenced by Sufism, often features the idea of longing for a "beloved," which can be interpreted both as a person and as a deeper spiritual or existential quest.

Shahid Ali's poetry is not only personal but also deeply resonant with readers across the world. His work has earned critical acclaim for its emotional depth, beauty, and

its ability to capture the human condition in its most vulnerable moments. Some of his most notable works include *The Half-Inch Himalayas*, *The Beloved Witness*, and *Call Me Ishmael Tonight*, which continue to be celebrated for their emotional intensity and the grace with which they explore themes of love, loss, and the search for home.

About the poem:

The poem "*The Right Image*" is about longing, loss, and the emotional void created by something or someone missing. The lake represents the speaker's inner emotional world, and the black swans represent deep, troubling emotions—possibly sorrow or despair—that disturb the calmness of this inner world. The reflection of the moon that is not there suggests the presence of something desired or idealized but ultimately unreachable.

In the context of Agha Shahid Ali's broader work, this poem could be interpreted as reflecting the pain of exile or loss, particularly the pain of being separated from one's homeland, a theme often explored in his poetry. The poem's sense of longing for something that is no longer present, yet still reflected in the mind, mirrors the feeling of living with memories or unattainable desires.

In short, the poem uses vivid and haunting imagery to evoke a deep sense of emotional turmoil—feelings of emptiness, loss, and longing that are difficult to express but are powerfully captured through the images of the lake, the black swans, and the absent moon.

Multiple-choice questions (MCQs)

1. What does the "lake" symbolize in the poem?

- a) A clear and peaceful mind
- b) The speaker's inner emotional world
- c) A place for physical reflection
- d) A calm and serene atmosphere

Answer: b) The speaker's inner emotional world

2. What is the significance of the "black swans" in the poem?

- a) They represent beauty and grace.
- b) They symbolize peace and harmony.
- c) They suggest unexpected or disturbing emotions, such as grief or sorrow.
- d) They signify hope and joy.

Answer: c) They suggest unexpected or disturbing emotions, such as grief or sorrow.

3. What does the "moon that is not there" represent in the poem?

- a) A symbol of unattainable beauty or ideal
- b) A light source
- c) A sign of hope and guidance
- d) A symbol of growth and renewal

Answer: a) A symbol of unattainable beauty or ideal

4. How is the "reflection of the moon" described in the poem?

- a) A strong, clear image
- b) A fleeting, barely visible reflection
- c) A reflection of a moon that is absent or missing
- d) A distorted image

Answer: c) A reflection of a moon that is absent or missing

5. What is the emotional tone of the poem?

- a) Joyful and celebratory
- b) Angry and resentful
- c) Melancholic and full of longing
- d) Optimistic and hopeful

Answer: c) Melancholic and full of longing

6. What does the use of "cutting" in relation to the black swans imply?

- a) The swans are peaceful and graceful.
- b) The swans are disturbing and disruptive.
- c) The swans are moving slowly.
- d) The swans are reflecting the moon.

Answer: b) The swans are disturbing and disruptive.

7. The absence of the moon in the poem suggests:

- a) The absence of beauty and hope
- b) A time of darkness and despair
- c) A source of light that is unreachable
- d) All of the above

Answer: d) All of the above

8. What might the "lake under my heart" symbolize in the poem?

- a) A physical body of water
- b) The speaker's emotional depth or inner feelings
- c) A peaceful mind
- d) A distant memory of the past

Answer: b) The speaker's emotional depth or inner feelings

9. The phrase "a flock, all black" implies:

- a) A group of swans of different colors
- b) The presence of negative emotions or grief
- c) A sense of unity and harmony
- d) A peaceful, harmonious scene

Answer: b) The presence of negative emotions or grief

10. What is the primary theme of the poem?

- a) The joy of being in nature
- b) The pain of separation and longing
- c) The beauty of moonlit nights
- d) The joy of reunion with loved ones

Answer: b) The pain of separation and longing

Q.2 Answer the following questions:

1. What does the "lake" symbolize in Agha Shahid Ali's poem "*The Right Image*"?
2. Why are the swans described as "all black"? What do they symbolize in the poem?
3. How does the absence of the moon in the poem affect the overall tone and meaning?
4. What role does the imagery of the "reflection" play in the poem?
5. How does the poem reflect Agha Shahid Ali's themes of loss and exile?

Q.3 Write short notes:

1. Discuss the symbolism of the lake, swans, and the moon in Agha Shahid Ali's poem "*The Right Image*".
2. Explain the tone and mood of the poem "*The Right Image*". How do the imagery and symbols contribute to the overall emotional impact of the poem?
3. How does Agha Shahid Ali use the image of the lake to represent the emotional landscape of the speaker?

3. Sunrise: Padma Sachdev

A sort of war was on between the clouds
and the sky.
The one was raining heavily, the other was
lightening, and it was
thundering between them.
The sun rose late from the thick layer of cloud,
semi-pale and
shaky yellow, like an arrogant school boy who
has been late
for his class.
"I am here now. Let the class start," he seems
to be boasting to
the clouds, still threatening in their rain.
But he tiptoed and sat in the corner of the last
bench, afraid of the
stern and angry stare of the sky.
The sky was writing on the blackboard that
the sun's colour had
changed, his slate was dirty, he had not eaten anything, and the
sun was trembling more and more.
Who has given the school master so much
wisdom to punish
the late-comers without knowing their real
reasons?
The sun is whispering to the clouds that there is no wisdom
in under estimating the gleams of the sun, and
there is no fixed time for the sun to rise.

About the Poet:

Padma Sachdev (17 April 1940 – 4 August 2021) was a famous Indian poet and writer. She is best known for being the first modern woman poet of the Dogri language. Dogri is spoken in the Jammu and Kashmir region of India.

Padma Sachdev wrote in Dogri and also in Hindi. Her poetry often talks about love, nature, and human emotions. She is considered an important figure in Dogri literature and helped make this language more well-known. She was a pioneer for women writers in the Dogri language.

About the Poem:

The poem “**Sunrise**” by **Padma Sachdev** is written in **Dogri** and translated into English by **Dr. Karan Singh**. It describes the sun’s behavior as it rises, using **imagery and comparisons** to teach a deeper lesson. The poet compares the sun to a **cataract in the eye**, showing how it can be unclear or hidden behind clouds. Later, the sun is compared to a **schoolboy** who reaches school late, pushing the clouds aside slowly and carefully.

The poem also shows the **sky as a disciplinarian**, questioning the sun for its lateness. This gives the poem a **playful, yet meaningful tone**. Through these images, the poet conveys that **nature has its own rules**, but there is no fixed schedule for everything. The poem also reflects qualities of the sun such as **pride, courage, and magnificence** when it shines fully in the sky.

Overall, the poem teaches about **timing, order, and the beauty of nature**, while also highlighting the sun’s personality and its interaction with the sky.

Main Ideas of the Poem:

1. **Reversal of Order:** The poem talks about how when things don’t follow the natural order (like a descending sun), it creates confusion.
2. **Importance of Following Rules:** Just as nature follows a pattern, people should also live by certain rules to keep balance in life.
3. **Chaos and Disruption:** When we ignore rules, it leads to **chaos** and **arrogance**, affecting both individuals and society.
4. **The Sun and Cataract Symbol:** The sun going down represents the **disruption of order**, and the cataract symbolizes how this disruption makes everything unclear.

The poem “**Sunrise**” by **Padma Sachdev** tells us that nature has a certain order, like the sun rising every day. We should also follow rules in life. When we don’t, it leads to **chaos** and **confusion**. The poet uses the image of the **sun descending** (going down) and a **cataract in the eye** to show how things can go wrong when the natural

order is disturbed. The poem reminds us that when rules and patterns are broken, the world feels unstable and uncertain.

Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

1. The sun is compared to a cataract in the poem because:

- a) It is full of sunspots
- b) It is not clear and is covered by clouds
- c) It is shaped like an eye
- d) It rises slowly

Answer: b) It is not clear and is covered by clouds

2. Why was the sky thundering in the poem?

- a) Because the sun was too bright
- b) Because the sun was rising late
- c) Because the clouds were too thick
- d) Because of the change in weather

Answer: b) Because the sun was rising late

3. Who was the sky angry with in the poem?

- a) The clouds
- b) The sun
- c) The birds
- d) The wind

Answer: b) The sun

4. The sun is compared to a schoolboy who:

- a) Comes out to play
- b) Is hesitating to rise
- c) Is late to school
- d) Starts shining brightly

Answer: c) Is late to school

5. Why does the poet compare the sun to a schoolboy in the poem?

- a) Because the sun is bright like a schoolboy
- b) Because the sun is afraid of the sky
- c) Because the sun is hesitating and rising late
- d) Because the sun is angry with the sky

Answer: c) Because the sun is hesitating and rising late

6. What is the sun's reply when the sky questions it about its late appearance?

- a) The sun says it was busy shining elsewhere
- b) The sun says there is no fixed time for sunrise
- c) The sun says it was hidden behind the clouds
- d) The sun says it was tired and needed rest

Answer: b) The sun says there is no fixed time for sunrise

7. Which adjective best describes the sun when it emerges from behind the clouds?

- a) Proud
- b) Fearful
- c) Glorious
- d) Bright

Answer: b) Fearful

8. What quality of the sun is described when it shines in all its splendor?

- a) Arrogant
- b) Humble
- c) Timid
- d) Shy

Answer: a) Arrogant

9. Who questions the sun in the poem?

- a) The clouds
- b) The sky
- c) The schoolmaster
- d) The birds

Answer: b) The sky

10. What emotion does the sky show in the poem?

- a) Happiness
- b) Anger
- c) Curiosity
- d) Sadness

Answer: b) Anger

11. How does the sky view the sun's lateness in the poem?

- a) With understanding
- b) With confusion
- c) With annoyance and anger
- d) With joy

Answer: c) With annoyance and anger

12. What message does the poet convey by showing the sun emerging slowly from behind the clouds?

- a) Nature should follow a fixed time
- b) The sun rises with arrogance
- c) Nature can't be controlled and follows its own rhythm
- d) The sun is always in a hurry

Answer: c) Nature can't be controlled and follows its own rhythm

13. What does the sun's behavior represent in the poem?

- a) Disobedience to nature
- b) The power of nature
- c) Arrogance and pride
- d) The balance of day and night

Answer: c) Arrogance and pride

14. Why is the sun's late rising compared to a cataract in the eye?

- a) Because the sun shines too brightly
- b) Because the sun's appearance is blurred, just like a cataract distorts vision
- c) Because the cataract blocks the sun's rays
- d) Because the cataract makes everything clear

Answer: b) Because the sun's appearance is blurred, just like a cataract distorts vision

15. What lesson can be learned from the poem "Sunrise"?

- a) Time is important and must be followed strictly
- b) Nature follows its own patterns, and everything happens in its own time
- c) The sun is always perfect and without flaws
- d) Humans should never question nature

Answer: b) Nature follows its own patterns, and everything happens in its own time

Q.2 Answer the following questions.

1. Why is the sun compared to a cataract in the poem?
Why was the sky thundering? Who was it angry with?
2. What does the poet compare the sun to as it comes out from behind the clouds? Why?
3. Who questions the sun and why?
4. What is the sun's reply when the sky questions it?
5. What adjectives can describe the sun:

Q.3 Write short notes.

1. Explain the comparison of the sun to a schoolboy in the poem "Sunrise".
2. Discuss the qualities of the sun as described in the poem. How does the poet show its pride and magnificence?
3. Explain the conversation between the sky and the sun. What lesson does it convey about nature and timing?
4. What is the significance of the sun being hidden behind clouds and then shining fully? What does it symbolize?

4. The House of My Childhood

The house of my childhood stood empty
On a grey hill All its furniture gone
Except my grandmother's grindstone
And the brass figurines of her gods
After the death of all birds
Bird-cries still fill the mind
After the city's erasure
A blur still peoples the air
In the colourless crack that comes before morning
In a place where nobody can sing
Words distribute their silence
Among intricately clustered glyphs
My grandmother's voice shivers on a bare branch
I toddle around the empty house
Spring and summer are both gone
Leaving an elderly infant
To explore the rooms of age

About the poet:

Dilip Chitre (1938–2009) was a prominent Indian poet, translator, and painter. He is known for his literary work in both Marathi and English, with poetry that often explores themes of nostalgia, loss, memory, and the passage of time, as seen in his poem *The House of My Childhood*. Chitre was also a skilled translator, especially noted for translating works of Marathi literature into English. His bilingualism allowed him to connect diverse cultural and literary traditions, making his work accessible to both Indian and international audiences. In addition to his poetry, he was also a visual artist, and his artwork reflected themes similar to those in his poetry. Chitre is widely regarded as one of the leading voices in contemporary Indian poetry.

About the Poem:

The House of My Childhood by Dilip Chitre is a poignant reflection on aging, memory, and loss. The poem captures the speaker's return to his childhood home, now empty and decaying, on a grey hill, symbolizing the passage of time and the inevitable erosion of both physical and emotional landscapes. The house, once filled with life, is now a ruin, with only his grandmother's grindstone and brass figurines of gods remaining as reminders of a vibrant past. Through vivid imagery, the poem evokes a deep sense of nostalgia for the warmth, spiritual life, and familial bonds that defined his childhood. However, with the loss of those days comes a profound sense of loneliness and isolation, as the speaker, now in the "winter" of his life, faces the emptiness of his old age. The absence of birds, the erasure of the city, and the silence in the place where "nobody can sing" all amplify the speaker's sense of desolation. The metaphor of being an "elderly infant" encapsulates the speaker's vulnerability and helplessness in his later years, suggesting a return to a state of innocence but without the support and care of his youth. The poem also touches on themes of spirituality, as the abandoned brass idols of the grandmother symbolize a loss of spiritual connection. Ultimately, *The House of My Childhood* is a meditation on the transient nature of life and the inevitable emotional void that follows the passing of time and the loss of loved ones.

Multiple-choice questions

1. What does the "empty house" symbolize in the poem?

- a) A place of happiness and memories
- b) The passage of time and loss
- c) A place of religious significance
- d) A symbol of wealth and prosperity

Answer: b) The passage of time and loss

2. What is the significance of "my grandmother's grindstone" and "the brass figurines of her gods"?

- a) They represent the cultural and religious heritage of the speaker's family.
- b) They are items of great material value.
- c) They signify the speaker's childhood games.
- d) They symbolize the idea of leaving home.

Answer: a) They represent the cultural and religious heritage of the speaker's family.

3. The line "After the death of all birds, Bird-cries still fill the mind" suggests that:

- a) The speaker is mourning the loss of nature.
- b) The speaker hears birds after they are gone.
- c) The sound of birds is forever etched in the speaker's memory.
- d) The birds have been silenced by the death of the speaker's grandmother.

Answer: c) The sound of birds is forever etched in the speaker's memory.

4. What does the "blur" after the city's erasure represent?

- a) The fading of the speaker's memories
- b) The city's destruction and loss of identity

- c) The difficulty in remembering exact details
- d) The passage of time and the empty space left behind

Answer: b) The city's destruction and loss of identity

5. What does the image of "My grandmother's voice shivers on a bare branch" evoke?

- a) A feeling of warmth and comfort
- b) The idea of loss and absence
- c) The arrival of spring
- d) The peacefulness of childhood

Answer: b) The idea of loss and absence

6. In the line "I toddle around the empty house", the speaker is:

- a) Describing a childhood memory
- b) Reflecting on their adult life
- c) Exploring the physical space of the house
- d) Playing with other children in the house

Answer: a) Describing a childhood memory

7. What is implied by "Spring and summer are both gone, Leaving an elderly infant"?

- a) The speaker is no longer a child, but feels spiritually young and naïve.
- b) The speaker is caught between childhood and old age.
- c) The speaker feels disconnected from time and age.
- d) The seasons are not relevant to the speaker's experience.

Answer: b) The speaker is caught between childhood and old age.

8. What do "Words distribute their silence Among intricately clustered glyphs" signify?

- a) The speaker is unable to speak or express emotions.
- b) The written words cannot capture the essence of what is lost.
- c) The silence is overpowering the words.
- d) The words in the poem are hard to understand.

Answer: b) The written words cannot capture the essence of what is lost.

9. The phrase "In a place where nobody can sing" suggests:

- a) A place of despair and quiet
- b) A happy and peaceful place
- c) A vibrant city where everyone is singing
- d) A metaphor for a place full of life

Answer: a) A place of despair and quiet

10. What does the speaker mean by "to explore the rooms of age"?

- a) The speaker is reflecting on their life experiences.
- b) The speaker is playing in the house, unaware of time.
- c) The speaker is living in a different time period.
- d) The speaker is becoming physically old and exploring new places.

Answer: a) The speaker is reflecting on their life experiences.

11. What is the "colourless crack that comes before morning" likely to symbolize?

- a) The quiet transition between night and day
- b) The dawn of a new day full of hope
- c) A metaphor for the passing of childhood
- d) The fading of memories from the past

Answer: c) A metaphor for the passing of childhood

12. The line "In a place where nobody can sing" suggests a theme of:

- a) Joy and celebration
- b) Loss of happiness and silence
- c) Community and togetherness
- d) A place full of music and life

Answer: b) Loss of happiness and silence

13. The phrase "I toddle around the empty house" conveys a feeling of:

- a) Adventure and discovery
- b) Loneliness and emptiness
- c) Happiness and curiosity
- d) Nostalgia and joy

Answer: b) Loneliness and emptiness

14. The "elderly infant" in the poem refers to:

- a) The poet's actual grandmother
- b) The speaker's own contradictory feeling of youth and age
- c) A metaphor for a person caught between two stages of life
- d) The loss of innocence and the arrival of old age

Answer: c) A metaphor for a person caught between two stages of life

15. In the line "Words distribute their silence Among intricately clustered glyphs", the term "glyphs" likely refers to:

- a) Musical notes
- b) A form of writing or symbolic language
- c) Pictures that tell a story
- d) The physical structure of the house

Answer: b) A form of writing or symbolic language

16. The absence of "birds" in the poem may represent:

- a) The speaker's disconnection from nature
- b) A sign of peace and tranquility
- c) The speaker's fear of silence
- d) The emotional void caused by loss

Answer: d) The emotional void caused by loss

17. The phrase "After the city's erasure" suggests:

- a) The city has physically disappeared
- b) The speaker is remembering an idyllic past
- c) The city's memories and significance have faded
- d) The destruction of a natural habitat

Answer: c) The city's memories and significance have faded

18. The "empty house" in the poem can be seen as a metaphor for:

- a) The physical and emotional abandonment
- b) A shelter that was once full of life
- c) The house that was destroyed by a storm
- d) A museum of childhood memories

Answer: a) The physical and emotional abandonment

19. The line "My grandmother's voice shivers on a bare branch" suggests that:

- a) The speaker is still haunted by their grandmother's memory
- b) The grandmother is physically present in the house
- c) The grandmother's voice is a symbol of vitality and youth
- d) The speaker finds comfort in the memory of the voice

Answer: a) The speaker is still haunted by their grandmother's memory

20. What is the symbolic meaning of "The brass figurines of her gods"?

- a) The speaker's connection to their religious and spiritual roots
- b) A sign of wealth and prosperity in the family
- c) The household items that have survived over time
- d) The transition from youth to old age in the family

Answer: a) The speaker's connection to their religious and spiritual roots

21. What does the phrase "A blur still peoples the air" convey?

- a) The speaker's inability to clearly remember the past
- b) A sense of nostalgia and longing for the past
- c) A vibrant city full of life and people
- d) The overwhelming presence of too many memories

Answer: a) The speaker's inability to clearly remember the past

22. The reference to "intricately clustered glyphs" suggests that:

- a) The house is filled with detailed memories
- b) The speaker is focusing on the written language to hold on to the past
- c) The speaker feels overwhelmed by the complexity of their emotions
- d) The language of the poem is purposely abstract and confusing

Answer: b) The speaker is focusing on the written language to hold on to the past

23. The "grindstone" in the poem is:

- a) A symbol of the speaker's childhood labor
- b) A functional item that has been passed down through generations
- c) An important object that holds emotional significance to the speaker
- d) A religious object in the family

Answer: c) An important object that holds emotional significance to the speaker

24. What does the speaker mean by "a place where nobody can sing"?

- a) A metaphor for a place devoid of happiness or joy
- b) A memory of childhood games
- c) A space filled with religious silence
- d) A place where the speaker can feel the presence of their ancestors

Answer: a) A metaphor for a place devoid of happiness or joy

25. The phrase "Spring and summer are both gone" most likely reflects:

- a) The passage of time and the end of youthful days
- b) The speaker's fondness for the seasons
- c) The literal change of seasons
- d) A moment of hope for a new beginning

Answer: a) The passage of time and the end of youthful days

Q.2 Answer the following questions.

1. What does the "empty house" mean in the poem?
2. What does the line "After the death of all birds, Bird-cries still fill the mind" suggest?
3. How does the poet describe the feeling of loss in the poem?
4. What is the mood of the poem? How does the poet make you feel?
5. What does "elderly infant" mean in the poem?
6. Why is the grandmother's grindstone important in the poem?

Q.3 Write short notes on the following.

1. What is the role of memory in the poem?
2. How is silence shown in the poem?
3. Why is the empty house important in the poem?
4. How does the speaker remember their grandmother?
5. What role do birds play in the poem?
6. How does time affect the speaker in the poem?
7. What does "a blur still peoples the air" mean?
8. What does the poem say about loss?

1. The Nation: Rabindranath Tagore

Rabindranath Tagore (1861-1941) was a renowned poet, novelist, and playwright widely acclaimed for his prolific literature in Bengali and English. His remarkable writings earned him the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1913 for his collection of prose poems called Gitanjali. In addition to his literary achievements, Tagore was a prominent educator who founded Visva Bharati University at Shantiniketan. This esteemed university is renowned for its internationalism and excellence in the arts and is now considered one of the leading universities in India.

In the following essay, Tagore reflects on the concept of nationalism and its relationship with culture. He argues that true nationalism should not be based on narrow and exclusive definitions of identity but should embrace diversity and celebrate the commonalities that unite humanity.

The People are living beings. They have their distinct personalities. But nations are organisations of power, and therefore their inner aspects and outward expressions are everywhere monotonously the same. Their differences are merely differences in the degree of efficiency.

In the modern world, the fight is going on between the living spirit of the people and the methods of nation-organizing. It is like the struggle that began in Central Asia between cultivated areas of man's habitation and the continually encroaching desert sands till the human region of life and beauty was choked out of existence. When the spread of higher ideals of humanity is not held to be important, the hardening method of national efficiency gains a certain strength; and for some limited period of time, at least, it proudly asserts itself as the fittest to survive. But it is the survival of that part of man which is the least living. And this is the reason why dead monotony is a sign of the spread of the Nation. The modern towns, which present the physiognomy due to this dominance of the Nation, are everywhere the same, from San Francisco to London, from London to Tokyo. They show no faces but merely masks.

The People, being living personalities, must have their self-expression, and this leads to their distinctive creations. These creations are literature, art, social symbols and ceremonials. They are like different dishes at one common feast. They add richness to our enjoyment and understanding of truth. They are making the world of man fertile of life and variedly beautiful.

But the nations do not create, they merely produce and destroy. Organisations for production are necessary. Even organisations for destruction may be so. But when actuated by greed and hatred, they crowd away into a corner the living man who creates, then the harmony is lost, and the people's history runs at a break-neck speed towards some fatal catastrophe.

Humanity, where it is living, is guided by inner ideals; but where it is a dead organisation, it becomes impervious to them. Its building process is only an external process, and in its response to the moral guidance it has to pass through obstacles that are gross and non-plastic.

Man as a person has his individuality, which is the field where his spirit has its freedom to express itself and to grow. The professional man carries a rigid crust around him which has very little variation and hardly any elasticity. This professionalism is the region where men specialise their knowledge and organise their power, mercilessly elbowing each other in their struggle to come to the front. Professionalism is necessary, without doubt; but it must not be allowed to exceed its healthy limits, to assume complete mastery over the personal man, making him narrow and hard, exclusively intent upon the pursuit of success at the cost of his faith in ideals.

In ancient India, professions were kept within limits by social regulation. They were considered primarily as social necessities and in second place as the means of livelihood for individuals. Thus man, being free from the constant urging of unbounded competition, could have the leisure to cultivate his nature in its completeness.

The Cult of the Nation is the professionalism of the people. This cult is becoming their greatest danger because it is bringing them enormous success, making them impatient of the claims of higher ideals. The greater the amount of success, the stronger the conflicts of interest and jealousy and hatred which are aroused in men's minds, thereby making it more and more necessary for other peoples, who are still living, to stiffen into nations. With the growth of nationalism, man has become the greatest menace to man. Therefore the continual presence of panic goads that very nationalism into ever-increasing menace.

Crowd psychology is a blind force. Like steam and other physical forces, it can be utilised for creating a tremendous amount of power. And therefore rulers of men, who, out of greed and fear, are bent upon turning their peoples into machines of power, try to train this crowd psychology for their special purposes. They hold it to

be their duty to foster in the popular mind universal panic, unreasoning pride in their own race, and hatred of others. Newspapers, school books, and even religious services are made use of for this object; and those who have the courage to express their disapprobation of this blind and impious cult are either punished in the law courts or are socially ostracised. The individual thinks, even when he feels; but the same individual, when he feels with the crowd, does not reason at all. His moral sense becomes blurred. This suppression of higher humanity in crowd minds is productive of enormous strength. For the crowd mind is essentially primitive; its forces are elemental. Therefore the Nation is forever watching to take advantage of this enormous power of darkness.

The people's instinct of self-preservation has been made dominant at particular times of crisis. Then, for the time being, the consciousness of its solidarity becomes aggressively wide awake. But in the Nation, this hyperconsciousness is kept alive for all time by artificial means. A man has to act the part of a policeman when he finds his house invaded by burglars. But if that remains his normal condition, then his consciousness of his household becomes acute and over-wrought, making him fly at every stranger passing near his house. This intensity of self-consciousness is nothing of which a man should feel proud; certainly, it is not healthful. In like manner, incessant self-consciousness in a nation is highly injurious for the people. It serves its immediate purpose but at the cost of the eternal in man.

When a whole body of men train themselves for a particular narrow purpose, it becomes a common interest with them to keep up that purpose and preach absolute loyalty to it. Nationalism is the training of a whole people for a narrow ideal; when it gets hold of their minds, it is sure to lead them to moral degeneracy and intellectual blindness. We cannot but hold firm the faith that this Age of Nationalism, of gigantic vanity and selfishness, is only a passing phase in civilisation, and those who are making permanent arrangements for accommodating this temporary mood of history will be unable to fit themselves for the coming age when the true spirit of freedom will have sway.

With the unchecked growth of Nationalism, the moral foundation of man's civilisation is unconsciously undergoing a change. The idea of the social man is unselfishness, but the idea of the Nation, like that of the professional man, is selfishness. This is why selfishness in the individual is condemned, while in the nation, it is extolled, which leads to hopeless moral blindness, confusing the religion of the people with the religion of the nation. Therefore, to take an example, we find men more and more convinced of the superior claims of Christianity merely because Christian nations are in possession of the greater part of the world. It is like

supporting a robber's religion by quoting the amount of his stolen property. Nations celebrate their successful massacre of men in their churches. They forget that Thugs also ascribed their success in manslaughter to the favour of their goddess. But in the case of the latter, their goddess frankly represented the principle of destruction. It was the criminal tribe's own murderous instinct deified—the instinct, not of one individual, but of the whole community, and therefore held sacred. In the same manner, in modern churches, selfishness, hatred and vanity in their collective aspect of national instincts do not scruple to share the homage paid to God.

Of course, the pursuit of self-interest need not be wholly selfish; it can even be in harmony with the interest of all. Therefore, ideally speaking, nationalism, which stands for the expression of the collective self-interest of a people, need not be ashamed of itself if it maintains its true limitations. But what we see in practice is that every nation which has prospered has done so through its career of aggressive selfishness, either in commercial adventures or in foreign possessions, or in both. And this material prosperity not only feeds continually the selfish instincts of the people but impresses men's minds with the lesson that, for a nation, selfishness is a necessity and, therefore, a virtue. It is the emphasis laid in Europe upon the idea of the Nation's constant increase of power, which is becoming the greatest danger to man, both in its direct activity and its power of infection.

We must admit that evils there are in human nature, in spite of our faith in moral laws and our training in self-control. But they carry on their foreheads their own brand of infamy, their very success adding to their monstrosity. All through man's history, there will be some who suffer and others who cause suffering. The conquest of evil will never be a fully accomplished fact but a continuous process like the process of burning in a flame.

In former ages, when some particular people became turbulent and tried to rob others of their human rights, they sometimes achieved success and sometimes failed. And it amounted to nothing more than that. But when this idea of the Nation, which has met with universal acceptance in the present day, tries to pass off the cult of collective selfishness as a moral duty, simply because that selfishness is gigantic in stature, it not only commits depredation but attacks the very vitals of humanity. It unconsciously generates in people's minds an attitude of defiance against the moral law. For men are taught by repeated devices the lesson that the Nation is greater than the people, while yet it scatters to the winds the moral law that the people have held sacred.

It has been said that a disease becomes most acutely critical when the brain is affected. For it is the brain that is constantly directing the siege against all disease forces. The spirit of national selfishness is that brain disease of a people which shows itself in red eyes and clenched fists, in the violence of talk and movements, all the while shattering its natural restorative powers. But the power of self-sacrifice, together with the moral faculty of sympathy and cooperation, is the guiding spirit of social vitality. Its function is to maintain a beneficent relation of harmony with its surroundings. But when it begins to ignore the moral law which is universal and uses it only within the bounds of its own narrow sphere, then its strength becomes like the strength of madness, which ends in self-destruction.

What is worse, this aberration of a people, decked with the showy title of 'patriotism', proudly walks abroad, passing itself off as a highly moral influence. Thus it has spread its inflammatory contagion all over the world, proclaiming its fever flush to be the best sign of health. It is causing in the hearts of people, naturally inoffensive, a feeling of envy at not having their temperature as high as that of their delirious neighbours and not being able to cause as much mischief but merely having to suffer from it.

I have often been asked by my Western friends how to cope with this evil, which has attained such sinister strength and vast dimensions. In fact, I have often been blamed for merely giving a warning and offering no alternative. When we suffer as a result of a particular system, we believe that some other system would bring us better luck. We are apt to forget that all systems produce evil sooner or later when the psychology which is at the root of them is wrong. The system which is national today may assume the shape of the international tomorrow; but so long as men have not forsaken their idolatry of primitive instincts and collective passions, the new system will only become a new instrument of suffering. And because we are trained to confound efficient systems with moral goodness itself, every ruined system makes us more and more distrustful of moral law.

Therefore I do not put my faith in any new institution but in the individuals all over the world who think clearly, feel noble, and act rightly, thus becoming the channels of moral truth. Our moral ideals do not work with chisels and hammers. Like trees, they spread their roots in the soil and their branches in the sky without consulting any architect for their plans.

About the Writer:

Rabindranath Tagore (1861–1941) was a renowned Bengali poet, philosopher, musician, and artist, best known for his contribution to literature and his winning of the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1913 for his poetry collection Gitanjali ("Song Offerings"). His works, which include novels like Gora and Chokher Bali, and numerous short stories, reflect deep humanism, spirituality, and social reform, focusing on themes like love, nature, and the human condition. Tagore was also a prolific composer of songs, known as Rabindra Sangeet, with over 2,000 compositions, and he wrote the national anthem of India, "Jana Gana Mana." In addition to his literary and musical achievements, Tagore founded Visva-Bharati University in 1921 in Shantiniketan, aiming to integrate traditional Indian learning with global knowledge. Although he initially supported Indian nationalism, he later criticized aggressive movements and the Partition of Bengal (1905). Tagore's legacy as a cultural icon continues to influence literature, music, and education globally, and his philosophical ideas on universal humanism and education remain relevant today.

About the prose:

The key points from Tagore's essay:

1. Nations vs. People:

- **People** are individual, creative beings who express themselves through things like **art**, **literature**, and **culture**.
- **Nations**, on the other hand, are systems of power focused on **efficiency** and **control**. This makes nations seem the same everywhere, leading to a loss of individual creativity and unique expression.
- Tagore says that nations are like factories, where people lose their individuality.

2. The Danger of Nationalism:

- **Nationalism** makes people **self-centered**, focusing only on their own nation's **power** and **success**.
- It causes people to forget about important values like **love** and **humanity**. Nationalism forces everyone to think the same way, making them **narrow-minded** and less creative.

3. Crowd Psychology and Manipulation:

- **Crowd psychology** means that when people are in a group, they often act without thinking. Leaders can **manipulate** the crowd by making them feel **pride** in their nation or **fear** of others.
- This mindless behavior makes it easier for rulers to control the people, using things like **media**, **schoolbooks**, and **religion** to spread ideas that keep people loyal to the nation.

4. Nationalism and the Cult of Selfishness:

- **Nationalism** encourages people to focus on **selfishness**, making them believe that **their nation's success** is a good thing, even if it happens at the expense of others.
- Nations often justify things like **war** and **colonization** by claiming they're morally superior. Tagore criticizes this idea, saying that national success is not always a sign of moral goodness.

5. Nationalism as Moral Blindness:

- Nationalism makes people **morally blind**—they start thinking that selfishness and violence are okay as long as they're done for the country.
- Tagore gives an example: Some nations use their **religion** to justify their actions, saying that their **violence** or **conquest** is a **divine mission**, which is morally wrong.

6. Nationalism's Harm to Humanity:

- Tagore argues that when nationalism becomes a **cult**, it makes people forget about **universal moral values** like peace and justice.
- People start caring only about **their nation** and forget about the **well-being of other people**. Nationalism encourages **selfishness**, and this harms humanity.

7. The Selfishness of Nations and Material Success:

- Nations gain **power** and **wealth** by being **selfish**—through things like **war**, **exploitation**, and **colonization**.

- This success leads to a dangerous lesson: **selfishness** is **acceptable** as long as the nation grows stronger. Tagore warns that this creates a society where people think it's okay to hurt others for personal gain.

8. The Temporary Nature of Nationalism:

- Tagore believes that **nationalism** is just a **temporary phase** in history. Nations will eventually realize that **higher ideals**—such as human **unity** and **peace**—are more important than nationalism.
- Nationalism, based on pride and selfishness, won't last forever. It's a passing phase in human history.

9. The Role of Individuals in Moral Progress:

- **Real progress** comes from **individuals** who are willing to act morally and live by **higher ideals**. These individuals, not nations, will help the world become better.
- Tagore places his faith in people who **think clearly**, **feel nobly**, and **act kindly**. These are the ones who truly change society.

10. Moral Ideals and Growth:

- **Moral values** don't need **systems** or **institutions** to grow. They come from individuals who practice them in their daily lives.
- Just like trees grow naturally, **moral truth** spreads when individuals live by it and share it with others.

11. Conclusion:

- **Nationalism** is a **dangerous idea** because it encourages **selfishness** and **division**. It ignores the **higher values** that connect all humans, like love, peace, and justice.
- True progress will only come when people move beyond **national pride** and focus on **human unity** and **moral truth** that is shared by everyone, regardless of nationality.

Q.1. Choose the correct alternatives from the following.

1. According to Tagore, **nations** are:

- a) Creative and expressive
- b) Focused on power and control**
- c) Concerned with individual expression
- d) Built on artistic values

Answer: b) Focused on power and control

2. What does Tagore say about **crowd psychology** in nationalism?

- a) It helps people think clearly
- b) It leads to mindless behavior and manipulation**
- c) It is beneficial for moral growth
- d) It encourages creativity

Answer: b) It leads to mindless behavior and manipulation

3. Tagore criticizes nationalism for promoting:

- a) Universal peace
- b) Selfishness and pride**
- c) Equality and justice
- d) Collective happiness

Answer: b) Selfishness and pride

4. The **cult of the nation** refers to:

- a) The worship of personal freedom
- b) The loyalty of individuals to the country's higher ideals
- c) The narrow focus on national pride and success**

d) Universal cooperation between nations

Answer: c) The narrow focus on national pride and success

5. Tagore believes that **nationalism** is:

a) A permanent feature of civilization

b) A necessary condition for peace

c) A temporary phase in history

d) The highest moral duty

Answer: c) A temporary phase in history

6. What is **Tagore's solution** for progress?

a) Rely on political systems

b) Focus on military power

c) Trust in individuals who act with higher moral ideals

d) Strengthen national borders

Answer: c) Trust in individuals who act with higher moral ideals

7. According to Tagore, **selfishness in nationalism** leads to:

a) Universal peace and unity

b) Conflict and moral blindness

c) Success for all people

d) Global cooperation

Answer: b) Conflict and moral blindness

8. Which of the following does Tagore criticize about **nationalism**?

a) It encourages self-sacrifice

b) It promotes individuality

c) **It glorifies selfishness and moral blindness**

d) It spreads humanitarian values

Answer: c) It glorifies selfishness and moral blindness

9. Tagore's view of **crowd psychology** is that:

a) It promotes reasoning

b) **It suppresses individual thought**

c) It encourages moral growth

d) It leads to personal success

Answer: b) It suppresses individual thought

10. Tagore believes that **moral progress** comes from:

a) Political systems

b) **Individuals upholding moral truth**

c) National pride

d) National institutions

Answer: b) Individuals upholding moral truth

11. According to Tagore, **nationalism** leads to:

a) Universal love

b) **Selfishness and greed**

c) Peace and unity

d) Moral growth

Answer: b) Selfishness and greed

12. Tagore compares **nations** to:

a) Gardens

b) **Machines of power**

c) Creative individuals

d) Living organisms

Answer: b) Machines of power

13. Tagore believes that **self-preservation** in a nation leads to:

a) Harmony

b) **Selfishness and constant conflict**

c) Moral understanding

d) Global peace

Answer: b) Selfishness and constant conflict

14. Tagore argues that when nations become too focused on self-interest, they:

a) Contribute to global unity

b) **Suppress creativity**

c) Help other nations prosper

d) Foster compassion

Answer: b) Suppress creativity

15. Tagore compares the **growth of nationalism** to:

a) A flower blooming

b) **A disease affecting the mind**

c) A river flowing

d) A tree's natural growth

Answer: b) A disease affecting the mind

16. What does Tagore believe nationalism does to a person's moral sense?

- a) Strengthens it
 - b) **Blurs it**
 - c) Elevates it
 - d) Makes it clearer
- Answer:** b) Blurs it

17. According to Tagore, **crowd psychology** is dangerous because:

- a) It helps individuals express creativity
 - b) **It leads to moral blindness and irrational actions**
 - c) It encourages reasoning
 - d) It promotes individual freedom
- Answer:** b) It leads to moral blindness and irrational actions

18. Tagore suggests that nationalism creates a society that:

- a) Values **individual freedom**
 - b) Encourages **self-sacrifice**
 - c) **Is selfish and focused on power**
 - d) Promotes love and peace
- Answer:** c) Is selfish and focused on power

19. According to Tagore, when nations become powerful through **selfishness**, they:

- a) Contribute to human progress
 - b) **Encourage further conflict and suffering**
 - c) Build stronger relationships with other nations
 - d) Become morally enlightened
- Answer:** b) Encourage further conflict and suffering

20. Tagore's main criticism of **nationalism** is that it:

- a) Promotes **unity and peace**
- b) Encourages **selfishness and violence**
- c) Fosters **creative thinking**
- d) Leads to global cooperation

Answer: b) Encourages selfishness and violence

Q.2. Answer the following questions.

1. How does Tagore describe the relationship between people and nations in the essay?
2. What is Tagore's main criticism of nationalism in the essay?
3. What role does **crowd psychology** play in nationalism, according to Tagore?
4. How does Tagore explain the idea of the 'cult of the nation' in the context of selfishness?
5. What does Tagore believe about the long-term effects of nationalism on societies?
6. What does Tagore mean by 'moral blindness' in the context of nationalism?
7. How does Tagore explain the **selfishness** that comes with nationalism?
8. What is Tagore's view on the role of individuals in overcoming the negative effects of nationalism?
9. How does Tagore use the example of ancient India to explain the balance between profession and individuality?
10. What does Tagore say about the dangers of nations justifying their actions through religion?

Q.3. Broad questions.

1. Discuss Tagore's views on the harmful effects of nationalism. How does nationalism affect individuals, morality, and society?
2. Explain Tagore's criticism of the cult of the nation and its impact on moral values.

3. What is Tagore's view on the role of individuals in overcoming the negative effects of nationalism?
4. How does Tagore use examples like the Thug cult and the justification of violence by nations to critique nationalism?
5. What is Tagore's solution for a world free from the dangers of nationalism?
6. Discuss the relationship between individual creativity and the concept of nationalism, according to Tagore.
7. How does nationalism lead to moral degeneration, according to Tagore's argument in the essay?
8. Tagore compares nationalism to a disease affecting the mind. Explain this analogy.
9. In what ways does Tagore believe that **selfishness** in nationalism weakens human unity?
10. Tagore suggests that nationalism is a passing phase in history. Discuss why he believes this and what he thinks will replace it.

2. Unity of Mind: A.P.J. Abdul Kalam

Unity Of Minds Following is the full text of the President's address to the nation on the eve of Independence Day.

My dear citizens of India,

On the eve of the 55th anniversary of our Independence, I have great pleasure in offering you my best wishes for your well-being and happiness. My salutations to all of you both in India and abroad.

May I extend a special word of gratitude to the men of our defence who guard our frontiers on the land, on the sea and in the air and paramilitary forces. May I also convey my special appreciation to our farmers who toil on the fields, technicians who keep the wheels of our industry moving, teachers who create knowledge products to the society and doctors, engineers, scientists, technologists and other professionals and administrators who are the prime movers of national development. May I wish the youth of India whose purposeful hard work with sweat will be a major transforming force for prosperous India.

I met some of the freedom fighters a few days ago at the Rashtrapati Bhavan. Each and every one of them was the live force for our freedom movement. On this day, I salute all men and women of India who fought for our freedom and sacrificed their lives to achieve our Independence. Seeding a great vision and an indomitable spirit to achieve India's freedom took place around 1857. For 90 years, there were a number of intensive struggles for freedom. Many of our people and leaders were in jail and their sufferings got transformed into freedom movement, with national ethos under the leadership of Mahatma Gandhi. I have tried to capture the essence of the freedom movement. Two aspects have come out: as a result of supreme sacrifices and dedicated and focused efforts, we got our Independence. The second aspect is that the vision driven movement itself created many leaders in different spheres of politics, economics, industry, science, arts and culture.

After Independence, India has made significant achievements in agriculture and food production, energy, healthcare, education and various fields of science and technology. Particularly we have made our mark in the international arena in the fields of pharmaceuticals, information technology, mass media and communication, space, defence and nuclear science. Similar to the first vision, which created a movement to achieve freedom with unity of minds of our people and the unity of purpose in actions, we need a second vision, which will integrate people from all walks of our society towards a common purpose. The second vision of our nation is

to transform it from the present developing status to a developed nation by integrated actions simultaneously in the areas of agriculture and food processing, education and healthcare, infrastructure development including power, information and communication technologies, and critical technologies. This greater vision will aim to alleviate poverty, illiteracy and unemployment. When the minds of the people of our country are unified and fused towards this vision, the dormant potential will manifest as a mammoth power leading to a happy and prosperous life of a billion people. This vision of the nation will also remove the conflicts arising out of differences and small thinking.

Dear citizens, I would like to reiterate that Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of India. It is not an international issue. India is ready for bilateral dialogue once the cross border terrorism is brought to a complete end. Normal election process is on in Jammu and Kashmir. It is essential to ensure its successful completion and dawn of peace in Jammu and Kashmir.

We also have many challenges in front of us. We have to find a solution to the repeated droughts and floods; we have to eradicate communal and other divisive clashes sprouting in certain parts and remove the pains of our people whether it is in Jammu and Kashmir or in any other part of our country; we also have to find a permanent solution to combat terrorism.

Let us now look at a long-term problem. It is paradoxical to see floods in one part of our country while some other parts face drought. This drought - flood phenomenon is a recurring feature. The need of the hour is to have a water mission which will enable availability of water to the fields, villages, towns and industries throughout the year, even while maintaining environmental purity.

One major part of the water mission would be networking of our rivers. Technological and 3 project management capabilities of our country can rise to the occasion and make this river networking a reality with long term planning and proper investment. In addition, the vast sea around us can help by providing potable water through desalination as a cost effective technology. There are of course short term techniques such as water harvesting by revitalizing rural ponds, water recycling to water conservation. Such programmes should have a large scale people participation even at the conceptual and project planning stages. The entire programme should revolve around economic viability leading to continued prosperity for our people with larger employment potential, environmental sustainability, grass root level motivation and benefit sharing.

I would now like to share with you friends, another crucial requirement and necessity for our country. We cannot sustain a second vision for the country without

Unity of Minds of all our people. Our great strength is our pluralistic tradition and civilisational heritage of nearly 3000 years. I have always been asking myself what the strength of our heritage is. A unique fusion has taken place with multiple cultures, religions and the way of life of many parts of the world and that has become the foundation of the Indian life. One can trace from 1857 to date, the type of good experiences we have had and also the strife resulting out of the differences in thoughts.

I have just now returned from Gujarat after interactions with various cross sections of people, leaders, officials and rehabilitation workers in the areas affected by recent disturbances and earthquake. I also visited the Sabarmati Ashram which was established by Mahatma Gandhi for the purpose of our countrymen to carry on the search for truth and develop fearlessness. I sat in silence for a while in the Ashram and remembered the life of Gandhiji. One dominant thought came to my mind. If we can go above our own personal hardships and see the problems of others and decide to work for a larger cause, then there is natural elevation of our minds. When we are lax in this, then our level of thinking goes down. I felt confident that all of us can be elevated to the level of noble minds, if we just decide to understand others and to practice tolerance. I realized that Gujarat has given the noble leader - Mahatma Gandhi, unifier of the nation - Vallabhbhai Patel and the great visionary in science and technology - Vikram Sarabhai and many more. Time has come for every one of us to put the thoughts of these great souls into action for nation's welfare.

Non-violence, tolerance, acceptance of all religions and different ways of life, search for truth and fearlessness are the values the Mahatma taught us and they are the cornerstones of our civilisational heritage and, therefore, of Indian polity. Any act by anyone anywhere in India that runs counter to these eternal values would pose a threat to the fabric of free Indian nation which was born and nurtured by the supreme sacrifices of countless noble souls. We should all work together to achieve the mission for Unity of Minds to preserve what we so preciously earned and reach greater heights in the future.

When I interact with school children and youth, wherever I go, one question comes often. They ask me "who are our role models?" Parents and teachers have to show them by example to live as enlightened citizens. Children also look for role models at national level in different fields. I have described earlier the role models from Gujarat. Each state of our country has many such examples of the past. It is now time we create more role models from the present. I suggest that members of our Parliament and Legislatures can shape the future of our children by becoming good role models. Parliament and Legislatures have a crucial role in giving the vision of developed India and value based polity. Our children should see the members of the

Parliament debating the vision of developed India, providing action plans and putting forth great thoughts and challenges to them. Looking at the national leaders, the children will find their role models for their development and growth.

I am sure, our leadership and our people can achieve the second vision of developed India. Let us take a vow on this Independence Day that the nation is more important compared to any individual, party or organisation.

I pray to the Almighty for Unity of Minds and our success in every aspect of life.
'Jai Hind'

About the Writer:

- **Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam** was the **11th President of India** (2002–2007) and a renowned scientist.
- He was known as the "**Missile Man of India**" for his work on India's missile and space programs.
- Dr. Kalam played a key role in the development of India's **nuclear weapons** and **ballistic missiles** as the principal scientific advisor to the government.
- He was deeply committed to India's progress, especially through **education** and **empowerment of youth**.
- Dr. Kalam was a simple, humble leader admired for his visionary ideas, particularly his focus on technology and innovation for national development.
- After his presidency, he continued to work as a mentor to students and young professionals, inspiring them to contribute to the nation's growth.

About the Speech:

- The speech was delivered by **Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam** on the **eve of India's 55th Independence Day** (August 14, 2002).
- **Main Theme:** The speech focused on **India's achievements** since independence and the **vision for the future** to make India a developed nation.
- **Key Points:**
 - Dr. Kalam praised India's progress in areas like **agriculture, healthcare, technology, and education**.
 - He emphasized the need for a **second vision** to transform India into a **developed nation**, focusing on critical areas like **infrastructure, education, and technology**.

- **Unity of Minds:** Dr. Kalam called for unity among the people of India to achieve national goals and overcome challenges like **poverty, unemployment, and illiteracy**.
- He reaffirmed that **Jammu and Kashmir** is an integral part of India and stressed the need for peace and dialogue with Pakistan after the cessation of **cross-border terrorism**.
- The speech also addressed **national challenges** such as **droughts, floods, and communal violence**, urging solutions through **water management** and **technological advancements**.
- Dr. Kalam emphasized the importance of **role models** for the youth and urged leaders to set examples for future generations.
- The speech concluded with a call for **national unity** and **selflessness**, placing the nation above personal or political interests, and ended with the patriotic slogan **“Jai Hind”**.

Important points to Remember:

1. Greetings and Well-Wishes

- The President wishes happiness and well-being to all citizens, both in India and abroad, on the eve of the 55th Independence Day.

2. Acknowledgment of Key Groups

- **Defense and Paramilitary Forces:** Gratitude for their protection of the nation.
- **Farmers, Technicians, and Professionals:** Appreciation for their hard work in agriculture, industry, education, and various fields.

3. Tribute to Freedom Fighters

- The President honors all those who fought for India's freedom, recognizing their sacrifices and contributions to the independence movement.

4. India's Achievements Since Independence

- Progress in sectors like **agriculture, healthcare, education, science, and technology**.
- Recognition of India's global achievements in **pharmaceuticals, IT, space, defense, and nuclear science**.

5. The Vision for a Developed India

- **Second Vision:** Transform India from a developing to a **developed nation** by focusing on:
 - **Agriculture**
 - **Education**
 - **Healthcare**
 - **Infrastructure**
 - **Critical technologies**
- The goal is to reduce **poverty**, **illiteracy**, and **unemployment**.

6. Unity of Minds for Progress

- Achieving progress depends on the **unity of minds** of all citizens, embracing India's **pluralistic** and **diverse heritage**.
- The importance of working together to overcome challenges and realize the second vision for the nation.

7. Jammu and Kashmir

- **Jammu and Kashmir** is an integral part of India.
- India is ready for bilateral dialogue with Pakistan, but only after **cross-border terrorism** ends.

8. Addressing National Challenges

- **Challenges** include recurring **droughts**, **floods**, **communal clashes**, and **terrorism**.
- Proposes solutions such as **water management** (e.g., **river networking** and **desalination** technology) to address water scarcity and related issues.

9. Role Models for Youth

- The need for **role models** from all parts of society, especially **Parliament members**, to inspire the younger generation.
- Leaders should set a positive example by focusing on the nation's development and promoting a **vision for India's future**.

10. National Unity Over Personal Interests

- The President calls for placing **the nation's welfare above individual, party, or organizational interests**.
- Encouragement for **collective effort** to make India a prosperous, developed nation.

11. Final Prayer for Unity

- The President prays for **Unity of Minds** and success in every aspect of life, urging everyone to work together for the country's prosperity.
- Ends with the patriotic slogan: **"Jai Hind"** (Victory to India).

Q.1. Choose the Correct Alternatives (MCQs):

1. **Who delivered the speech on the eve of India's 55th Independence Day?**
a) Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam
b) Jawaharlal Nehru
c) Mahatma Gandhi
d) Indira Gandhi
Answer: a) Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam
2. **Which year was India's 55th Independence Day celebrated?**
a) 2001
b) 2002
c) 2003
d) 2004
Answer: b) 2002
3. **What is Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam also known as?**
a) Father of the Nation
b) Missile Man of India
c) Iron Man of India
d) Architect of India
Answer: b) Missile Man of India
4. **Which sector did Dr. Kalam NOT mention as a key area of progress in India?**
a) Agriculture
b) Healthcare
c) Fashion industry

d) Technology

Answer: c) Fashion industry

5. **What is the second vision for India that Dr. Kalam mentions?**

a) To become a global superpower

b) To transform India into a developed nation

c) To become a leader in entertainment

d) To end poverty by 2025

Answer: b) To transform India into a developed nation

6. **According to Dr. Kalam, what is the key to achieving national success?**

a) International aid

b) Unity of minds

c) Political parties

d) Military power

Answer: b) Unity of minds

7. **Which region did Dr. Kalam emphasize as an integral part of India?**

a) Punjab

b) Jammu and Kashmir

c) Tamil Nadu

d) Goa

Answer: b) Jammu and Kashmir

8. **What does Dr. Kalam suggest is needed to solve the issue of floods and droughts?**

a) Better government policies

b) A water mission and river networking

c) International aid

d) Tourism development

Answer: b) A water mission and river networking

9. **Dr. Kalam speaks about creating role models in which group of people?**

a) Teachers

b) Politicians and Members of Parliament

c) Scientists

d) Farmers

Answer: b) Politicians and Members of Parliament

10. **What does Dr. Kalam suggest is the foundation of India's strength?**

a) Military power

b) Unity in diversity

c) Economic growth

d) Technological advancements

Answer: b) Unity in diversity

11. **What is the primary focus of the "second vision" for India?**

- a) Creating more jobs in entertainment
- b) Improving agriculture, education, and healthcare
- c) Reducing international tensions
- d) Developing a stronger military

Answer: b) Improving agriculture, education, and healthcare

12. **Which key value does Dr. Kalam emphasize in his speech?**

- a) Independence
- b) Non-violence and tolerance
- c) War and peace
- d) Socialism

Answer: b) Non-violence and tolerance

13. **What was the significant problem Dr. Kalam highlighted regarding water?**

- a) Overuse of water
- b) Shortage and mismanagement
- c) Water pollution
- d) Global warming

Answer: b) Shortage and mismanagement

14. **What does Dr. Kalam suggest should guide the younger generation?**

- a) Politics
- b) Role models from present-day leaders
- c) Historical figures only
- d) Fame and wealth

Answer: b) Role models from present-day leaders

15. **Dr. Kalam urges citizens to prioritize which of the following?**

- a) Personal ambitions
- b) Political party interests
- c) National development and welfare
- d) Global trade relations

Answer: c) National development and welfare

16. **In which field did India make its mark internationally, according to Dr. Kalam?**

- a) Fashion
- b) Sports
- c) Pharmaceuticals
- d) Tourism

Answer: c) Pharmaceuticals

17. **What does Dr. Kalam believe should be the focus for the nation in the coming years?**

- a) Expansion of cities
- b) Unity and collective effort for development
- c) Increase in military spending
- d) Better tourism policies

Answer: b) Unity and collective effort for development

18. **Who did Dr. Kalam praise for their sacrifices in the speech?**

- a) Teachers
- b) Politicians
- c) Freedom fighters
- d) Businessmen

Answer: c) Freedom fighters

19. **What does Dr. Kalam believe will happen if the minds of the people are unified?**

- a) National conflicts will increase
- b) India will be able to tackle challenges effectively
- c) India will face more social issues
- d) Growth will slow down

Answer: b) India will be able to tackle challenges effectively

20. **Dr. Kalam ends his speech with which slogan?**

- a) Bharat Mata Ki Jai
- b) Vande Mataram
- c) Jai Hind
- d) Inquilab Zindabad

Answer: c) Jai Hind

Q.2. Answer the Following Questions.

1. What special thanks did Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam extend in his speech?
2. How does Dr. Kalam describe the role of freedom fighters in India's struggle for independence?
3. What are the two aspects of India's freedom movement mentioned by Dr. Kalam?
4. How does Dr. Kalam describe India's progress since independence?
5. What is the 'second vision' for India that Dr. Kalam talks about?
6. Why does Dr. Kalam emphasize the 'Unity of Minds' in his speech?
7. What challenges does Dr. Kalam identify for India in the future?
8. What solution does Dr. Kalam propose for dealing with the recurring problem of floods and droughts in India?

9. What role do leaders and politicians play in shaping the future of India, according to Dr. Kalam?
10. How does Dr. Kalam define the strength of India's heritage and its role in national progress?

Q.3. Broad Questions.

1. Discuss the importance of 'Unity of Minds' as explained by Dr. Kalam in the context of India's development.
2. Explain Dr. Kalam's vision for transforming India into a developed nation and the key areas he emphasizes for this transformation.
3. How does Dr. Kalam connect the values taught by Mahatma Gandhi to the present challenges facing India?
4. What is the significance of Dr. Kalam's visit to Gujarat, and what insights does he gain from it?
5. How does Dr. Kalam suggest that the youth can contribute to building a prosperous and developed India?
6. What role does tolerance and non-violence play in Dr. Kalam's vision for India's future?
7. In what ways does Dr. Kalam propose to address issues like communal violence, terrorism, and regional conflicts?
8. What are the steps Dr. Kalam suggests to manage India's water resources and address the issue of water scarcity?
9. What does Dr. Kalam mean by "the nation is more important compared to any individual, party, or organization"?
10. How does Dr. Kalam envision the involvement of parliamentarians and other leaders in shaping India's future?

3. Sudha Murty: The Woman who Inspires Many: by Reena Shah

Reena is the section editor of the Inspiration section of Jain Digest. She has a Ph. D. in English literature and a USC grad. She currently teaches English to high school students. Teaching has always been a passion and she loves to read and write. She is dedicated to lifelong learning and continuing education. Her industry experience includes Market Research, Non-Profit, and educational institutions. She practices deeper aspects of spirituality and is a follower of the Late Param Pujya Pappaji at Shrimad Rajchandra Aatma Tatva Research Centre, Parli, Near Mumbai.

A writer, philanthropist and an entrepreneur, Sudha Murty is greatly admired and respected for being a prolific writer and being one of the brains behind Infosys - one of India's leading IT companies. Soberly dressed in traditional Indian attire, she is also globally recognized for her philanthropic work - facilitating the education of poor children, passion & compassion to fight for women's rights, ability to speak her mind, simplicity, and her humility. On April 5, 2023, she received Padma Bhushan award for her immense contribution to the field of social work from India's President Draupadi Murmu. Her multifaceted personality has been a tremendous source of inspiration for me.

Early Life and Education Born

in the small town of Shiggaon in Karnataka, India, Sudha Murty had the passion to excel right from her childhood. She was born into a family that valued education and hard work. Sudha's parents encouraged her to pursue her dreams even when the odds were against her. Sudha Murty earned her B.E. in Electrical and Electronics Engineering from the B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology in Hubli (presently known as KLE Technological University), which she followed with an M.E. in Computer Science from the globally renowned Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore, in 1974. An excellent student, she was a top student in both her bachelor's and master's degrees.

Brilliant Penmanship

Sudha Murty is also a prolific author who has published over ninety-five titles in sixteen Indian languages. She has received many awards at the state, national, and international levels, including the Rajyaprashasti, and six doctorates from universities across India. Her books focus on a variety of societal and civic issues while also entertaining and educating the masses and the children. Her books are known for their simplicity, humor, and ability to connect with readers of all ages.

She is India's highest-selling female author. She has been a role model to many writers and women around the world.

Fearless and Confident

Sudha's passion for learning and her curious nature led her to study engineering at B.V.B. College of Engineering and Technology in Hubli. It is simply incredible to note that she was the only female student at her engineering college in Hubli. Her male classmates weren't derisive, but they certainly didn't conceal their amusement at having a girl in their carpentry workshop. "I never missed a single class because I knew if I did no one would help me. It made me self-sufficient. It also made me talk to boys on equal terms," she shares. Sudha was accepted to the college by the principal with the three utterly illogical requirements of always wearing a saree there, never eating in the canteen, and never engaging in conversation with male students. A woman's journey towards pursuing her dreams and ambitions consists of several bumps of societal bias. There have been several sectors that had their gates open for 'Men only'. She is known for her feisty letter to JRD Tata in reaction to a TELCO (now Tata Motors) job notice inviting applications for trainee engineers, where women were asked not to apply. She was subsequently hired as their first female engineer. It was there that she met her future husband, Narayana Murty, who would later become her partner in life and philanthropy. Sudha's hard work and dedication soon paid off, and she was promoted to the position of Senior Systems Analyst. Despite her success in the corporate world, she felt that something was missing in her life. Sudha Murty has worked tirelessly to be a strong voice in educating people on the need to overcome gender inequality in all aspects of life. Her work is an inspiration for all who strive to achieve gender parity and combat sexism. She is portrayed as a lady who is opposed to any kind of discrimination against women. She has no qualms in showing this to anyone regardless of age or designation. In her book, *Women@Work*, she discusses the challenges that women face in the workplace and how they can rise to the occasion by taking charge of their careers and manage their time effectively. A woman who refused to stay on the sidelines because of the large gender bias of the country, Sudha is an icon to the youth of today.

Genuine and Humble

Sudha Murty is easily one of the richest women in the country but is far from flaunting her wealth to the masses. One of her key aspects is the simple values that she adheres to in a world that emphasizes materialism. She sure knows the art of simplicity, and being a genuine human being is something she does flawlessly! "No jewelry or new saris for me... I have everything I need," says Murty. Three days in a year she goes to the Raghavendra Swamy temple in Jayanagar. She cleans the

kitchen and the adjoining rooms; washes the dirty utensils, dusts the shelves, chops vegetables, takes inventory of stock, sweeps the yard, and empties the trash cans. Influenced by the Sikh philosophy of Kar Seva, Sudha believes that it is easy to give money but devoting yourself to physical seva is not. She further added that we are all equal in the eye of God but not in the eyes of society. Her legacy will continue to inspire generations to come, reminding us all that one person can make a difference in the world. “If you really understand life, power and money should not affect you. But you require a strong mind for that. Don’t be carried away with power, with money. Enjoy the small things and work hard and with honesty. It may not pay you immediately, but in the longer run you can create something good,” she said. Simple living and high thinking are her philosophies that continue to inspire people all around the globe.

Gives Back to Society

One of the best things that we as human beings can do is care for the underprivileged. Sudha Murty stands by the belief that money always changes hands and that giving back to society fosters significant goodwill. Her noble beliefs are reflected in her active participation in social work for art and culture, public hygiene, healthcare, poverty alleviation, and women empowerment and education. In 1996, she founded Infosys Foundation, the philanthropic arm of Infosys Technologies. Through the foundation, Sudha focused on healthcare, education, and rural development. She worked tirelessly to build schools, hospitals, and community centers across India, helping to improve the lives of countless people in underprivileged communities. One of Sudha Murty’s defining moments in her life was when 3,000 rehabilitated sex workers arranged a thanksgiving ceremony for her after 18 years of tirelessly working with them to empower them to lead a normal life. She said, “I went there on the stage and the 3,000 of them, who were now leading normal lives, wanted to hear from me and I was absolutely speechless. The tears started to flow, and I quoted a shloka from Ramayana: ‘God... don’t make me rich, don’t make me beautiful, don’t make me a queen. If at all you want to give me anything, give me a soft heart and a strong hand, so I can wipe the tears of others.’ At that moment, I realized why I was born, and it gave me a tremendous amount of peace.” A tremendously inspirational moment! Sudha's work with the Infosys Foundation earned her many accolades and awards, including the Padma Shri, one of India's highest civilian honors. Sudha Murty is an undeniable source of motivation for many in the Indian literary scene. Her life story is a testament to the power of hard work, dedication, and a willingness to help others. From her incredible achievements to her charitable works, she has demonstrated that true success comes from adding value and making a difference to the lives of others. Sudha is a terrific example of how anyone can make it big if they put their mind to it, no matter where

they come from or what challenges life throws at them. We should learn from her exemplary life and strive to be like her in order to create positive change around us. [To learn more about Sudha Murty, many articles, and news stories are available online. There are many YouTube videos of her interviews and speeches.]

About The Writer:

Reena Shah is an accomplished writer and the section editor of the *Inspiration* section of **Jain Digest**. With a **Ph.D. in English Literature** and a degree from the **University of Southern California (USC)**, she brings a strong academic background to her work. Currently, she teaches English to high school students, a profession she is deeply passionate about, and is dedicated to lifelong learning and education. Reena's career spans across various industries, including **Market Research, Non-Profit, and Educational Institutions**. Beyond her professional endeavors, she is a follower of **Late Param Pujya Pappaji** at the **Shrimad Rajchandra Aatma Tatva Research Centre** in **Parli**, near Mumbai, where she practices deeper aspects of **spirituality**. Avid about reading and writing, Reena is committed to sharing knowledge and inspiring others through her work.

About An Article:

The article, "*Sudha Murty: The Woman who Inspires Many*", written by **Reena Shah**, offers a comprehensive look at the life and achievements of **Sudha Murty**, a renowned writer, philanthropist, and entrepreneur. It highlights her multifaceted personality and contributions to various fields, particularly her **philanthropic work** and her role in **Infosys**, one of India's leading IT companies. The article details Sudha Murty's **early life**, her **educational journey**, and her significant **career milestones**, including her groundbreaking work as the first female engineer at **TELCO** (now Tata Motors).

The piece also delves into Sudha Murty's **writing career**, where she has authored over **ninety-five books** in multiple languages, gaining recognition as **India's highest-selling female author**. Reena Shah emphasizes Sudha's **fearlessness** in overcoming societal biases, especially as a woman in a male-dominated field, and her commitment to **gender equality**.

The article further explores Sudha Murty's **humility** and **simple living**, despite her vast wealth, and her dedication to **social work**, particularly in areas such as **education, healthcare, and poverty alleviation** through her **Infosys Foundation**.

Sudha's **selfless service** is highlighted through her impactful work with underprivileged communities and her contributions to **women's empowerment**.

In conclusion, the article portrays Sudha Murty as a role model who exemplifies **hard work, humility, and compassion**, inspiring countless individuals to live purposeful and meaningful lives while making a positive difference in the world.

The important points from the article about Sudha Murty:

1. Introduction:

- **Sudha Murty**: A writer, philanthropist, and entrepreneur.
- Co-founder of **Infosys**, one of India's leading IT companies.
- Renowned for her **philanthropic work**, focusing on education, women's rights, and societal issues.
- **Padma Bhushan award** recipient in 2023 for her contributions to social work.

2. Early Life and Education:

- **Born**: In Shiggaon, Karnataka, India.
- **Family**: Valued education and hard work.
- **Education**:
 - **B.E. in Electrical and Electronics Engineering** from B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology, Hubli.
 - **M.E. in Computer Science** from Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore (1974).
- Was a top student in both her bachelor's and master's degrees.

3. Career and Achievements:

- **Career**:
 - Became the first female engineer at TELCO (now Tata Motors).
 - Promoted to **Senior Systems Analyst**.
 - Co-founded **Infosys** with her husband, Narayana Murthy.
- **Writing**:
 - Published over **95 titles** in 16 Indian languages.
 - Known for books that tackle societal issues with simplicity, humor, and depth.
 - **India's highest-selling female author**.
- **Awards**:

- Multiple national and international awards, including **Rajyaprashasti**.
- Received **six honorary doctorates** from universities across India.

4. Gender Equality and Advocacy:

- **Challenges as a Woman:**
 - Faced gender bias in engineering; she was the only female student at her college.
 - Fought against societal restrictions placed on women, including in her early workplace.
- **Advocacy:**
 - **Letter to JRD Tata:** Fought for women's inclusion in engineering roles at TELCO.
 - **Women@Work:** A book discussing the challenges women face in the workplace and how they can overcome them.

5. Simple Living and Humility:

- **Simple Living:**
 - Despite being one of the richest women in India, Sudha Murty practices humility and simple living.
 - **No new jewelry or fancy clothes;** prefers to live simply.
 - Actively engages in **physical seva** (voluntary service), influenced by Sikh philosophy.
- **Personal Values:**
 - Believes in working with honesty and simplicity.
 - Quotes on life: "Don't be carried away with power, with money. Enjoy the small things."

6. Philanthropy and Social Work:

- **Infosys Foundation (1996):** Established to focus on **healthcare, education, and rural development**.
 - Built schools, hospitals, and community centers across India.
- **Work with Underprivileged:**
 - Empowered **sex workers**, helping 3,000 rehabilitated sex workers lead normal lives.
 - **Quote from Ramayana:** "God... give me a soft heart and a strong hand, so I can wipe the tears of others."
- **Recognition:**
 - **Padma Shri** for her contributions to social work.

- Awarded for her efforts in art, culture, and community development.

7. Conclusion and Legacy:

- Sudha Murty's life exemplifies **hard work, dedication, and compassion**.
- Her **legacy** is one of **inspiration**, showing that one can make a difference by helping others and following a simple, honest life.
- A true example of how individuals can rise above challenges and create positive change in society.

Multiple-choice questions (MCQs)

1. Who is the author of the article "Sudha Murty: The Woman who Inspires Many"?

- a) Narayana Murthy
- b) Reena Shah
- c) J.R.D. Tata
- d) Sudha Murty

Answer: b) Reena Shah

2. What is the role of Sudha Murty in Infosys?

- a) CEO
- b) Co-founder
- c) Marketing Head
- d) Senior Systems Analyst

Answer: b) Co-founder

3. Which award did Sudha Murty receive on April 5, 2023?

- a) Padma Shri
- b) Padma Bhushan
- c) Rajyaprashasti
- d) Booker Prize

Answer: b) Padma Bhushan

4. In which state was Sudha Murty born?

- a) Maharashtra
- b) Karnataka
- c) Tamil Nadu
- d) Kerala

Answer: b) Karnataka

5. Where did Sudha Murty complete her M.E. in Computer Science?

- a) IIT Bombay
- b) Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore
- c) University of California
- d) B.V.B. College of Engineering

Answer: b) Indian Institute of Science, Bangalore

6. How many books has Sudha Murty written?

- a) 75
- b) 95
- c) 100
- d) 120

Answer: b) 95

7. Which book did Sudha Murty write that discusses challenges women face at work?

- a) Women@Work
- b) Simple Living, High Thinking
- c) Life and Living
- d) The Power of Dreams

Answer: a) Women@Work

8. What unique role did Sudha Murty have at TELCO (now Tata Motors)?

- a) First female engineer
- b) Head of marketing
- c) CEO
- d) Software Developer

Answer: a) First female engineer

9. Which major philosophy influences Sudha Murty's practice of service (seva)?

- a) Hinduism
- b) Sikhism
- c) Buddhism
- d) Jainism

Answer: b) Sikhism

10. What is the main focus of the Infosys Foundation, founded by Sudha Murty?

- a) Economic development
- b) Healthcare, education, and rural development
- c) Technological advancements
- d) Corporate management

Answer: b) Healthcare, education, and rural development

11. What was Sudha Murty's stance on gender inequality?

- a) She believed in accepting gender roles
- b) She ignored gender bias in workplaces
- c) She actively fought against gender discrimination
- d) She thought women should remain at home

Answer: c) She actively fought against gender discrimination

12. Which of the following is Sudha Murty's view on wealth?

- a) Wealth should be flaunted
- b) Money and power should define one's life
- c) She practices simple living despite her wealth
- d) Wealth is a measure of success

Answer: c) She practices simple living despite her wealth

13. Which significant ceremony was held to honor Sudha Murty's work with sex workers?

- a) A temple prayer
- b) A thanksgiving ceremony with 3,000 rehabilitated sex workers
- c) A national award function
- d) A corporate event in Infosys

Answer: b) A thanksgiving ceremony with 3,000 rehabilitated sex workers

14. Which of the following qualities is Sudha Murty known for?

- a) Opulence and extravagance
- b) Simplicity and humility
- c) Wealth and fame
- d) Luxury and materialism

Answer: b) Simplicity and humility

15. Where did Sudha Murty study for her Bachelor's degree?

- a) Indian Institute of Technology
- b) B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology, Hubli
- c) University of Mumbai
- d) University of Bangalore

Answer: b) B.V.B. College of Engineering & Technology, Hubli

16. What was the condition set by Sudha Murty's college principal when she was admitted?

- a) She should wear western clothes
- b) She should never eat in the canteen
- c) She should always wear a saree
- d) She should avoid engaging with male students

Answer: c) She should always wear a saree

17. Sudha Murty received which honorary title for her contribution to social work?

- a) Nobel Peace Prize
- b) Padma Shri
- c) Bharat Ratna
- d) Rajyaprashasti

Answer: b) Padma Shri

18. What is one of Sudha Murty's key philosophies?

- a) "Power and money should rule your life"
- b) "Material wealth is the goal of life"
- c) "Simple living and high thinking"
- d) "Luxury is essential to happiness"

Answer: c) "Simple living and high thinking"

19. How many honorary doctorates has Sudha Murty received?

- a) 4
- b) 6
- c) 8
- d) 10

Answer: b) 6

20. Sudha Murty's work focuses on which of the following societal issues?

- a) Urbanization and technology
- b) Political reforms
- c) Women empowerment, healthcare, and education
- d) Corporate ethics

Answer: c) Women empowerment, healthcare, and education

Q.2. Answer the following Questions.

1. Explain the early life and education of Sudha Murty.
2. How did Sudha Murty break gender barriers in her early career?
3. Discuss the significance of the **Infosys Foundation** and its impact on society.
4. Describe Sudha Murty's approach to **philanthropy** and social work.
5. What were some challenges Sudha Murty faced as a woman in engineering?
6. How has Sudha Murty contributed to the **literary world**?
7. What is Sudha Murty's philosophy on **simple living** and **humility**?
8. How did Sudha Murty react to the gender bias in the TELCO job advertisement?
9. Discuss the **social issues** Sudha Murty focuses on in her books.
10. What is the significance of Sudha Murty's **Padma Bhushan** award?

Q.3. A broad questions.

1. Discuss the multifaceted personality of Sudha Murty and how her work in literature, engineering, and philanthropy has inspired people across the globe.
2. How did Sudha Murty's humble beginnings in Shiggaon shape her career and personal life?

3. Analyze the challenges Sudha Murty faced as a woman in a male-dominated engineering field and how she overcame them.
4. Explain Sudha Murty's contributions to women's rights and gender equality, both in her personal life and through her work.
5. Discuss the role of **education and healthcare** in Sudha Murty's philanthropic endeavors and their impact on rural communities in India.
6. In what ways has Sudha Murty's **personal values and humility** influenced her work with the Infosys Foundation and her role as a philanthropist?
7. How does Sudha Murty's life exemplify the principle of "**simple living and high thinking**"?
8. Evaluate the significance of Sudha Murty's letter to **JRD Tata** and how it reflects her determination to break gender stereotypes in the workplace.
9. Describe Sudha Murty's contributions to the empowerment of **underprivileged women**, particularly through her work with rehabilitated sex workers.
10. What lessons can we learn from Sudha Murty's life and work in terms of **personal growth, education, and giving back to society**?